“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 22

The Discourse on the Truth of Bhakti as the Abhidheya

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 I worship Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanyadeva, the ocean of mercy, by whom this most hidden bhakti was revealed even in the age of Kali.[1]

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya and Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura![2]

3 “Thus I have explained to you the truth of *sambandha*. All the Vedas and śāstras teach that Kṛṣṇa is the one essence.[3]

4 Now listen as I describe *abhidheya*, the means by which one attains Kṛṣṇa and the treasure of love for Kṛṣṇa.

5 All the scriptures declare that devotion to Kṛṣṇa is the *abhidheya*, and so the sages have concluded.

6 “When Mother Śruti is asked, she points out the way to worship You. Smṛti, her sister, speaks just as the mother does, and the Purāṇas and the rest, like brothers, follow her. Therefore, O slayer of Mura, I have truly understood that You alone are my shelter.” (Words of a sage)[4]

7 Kṛṣṇa, the nondual Truth (*advaya-jñāna-tattva*), is Bhagavān Himself. He abides in the form of His own potency (*svarūpa-śakti*).[5]

8 Expanding Himself as His own parts (*svāṁśa*) and separated parts (*vibhinnāṁśa*), He enjoys His pastimes in endless Vaikuṇṭhas and universes.[6]

9 His own parts are the *catur-vyūha* and the host of avatāras. The jīva is His separated part and is counted among His energies.

10 Those jīvas, His separated parts, are of two kinds: some are eternally liberated (*nitya-mukta*), and some are eternally in worldly existence (*nitya-saṁsāra*).

11 The eternally liberated are ever turned towards Kṛṣṇa's feet. They are called Kṛṣṇa's associates (*pārṣadas*), and they enjoy the happiness of serving Him.

12 The eternally bound (*nitya-baddha*) jīva is forever turned away from Kṛṣṇa. Eternally caught in worldly existence, he suffers the miseries of hell and the like.

13 For this fault the witch Māyā punishes him: the threefold miseries, beginning with those of body and mind (*ādhyātmika*), wear him down and torment him.

14 Having become the servant of lust and anger, he suffers her kicks. But if, wandering on and on, he meets a sādhu, a physician of the soul,

15 by the mantra of that sādhu's instruction the witch flees. The soul obtains devotion to Kṛṣṇa and then draws near to Kṛṣṇa.

16 “How many evil commands of lust and the rest have I not obeyed, and in how many ways! Yet they never took pity on me, nor did I feel shame or find peace. Now, O Lord of the Yadus, I have cast them off; good sense has dawned in me, and I have come to You, the fearless shelter. Engage me in Your service.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, Paścima-vibhāga, Prīti-bhakti-laharī, 6)

17 Devotion to Kṛṣṇa is the chief *abhidheya*. Karma, yoga and jñāna all look to the face of bhakti for their results.[7]

18 The strength of all these practices is very feeble: without devotion to Kṛṣṇa they cannot give any fruit.

19 “Even stainless knowledge, free from all action (*naiṣkarmya*), does not shine if it is devoid of love for Acyuta. How then can action shine, ever inauspicious as it is, if it is not offered to the Lord, even when it is free of selfish motive?” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.5.12)[8]

20 “Ascetics, the generous, the renowned, the thoughtful, the knowers of mantras and those of auspicious conduct — none of them attains true welfare without offering everything to Him. Again and again I bow to Him, whose fame is auspicious.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.4.17)

21 Knowledge alone cannot give liberation without bhakti; but to one turned towards Kṛṣṇa that liberation comes even without knowledge.

22 “O almighty Lord, bhakti to You is the path to the highest good. Those who reject it and toil only to gain knowledge are left with nothing but their toil, like those who pound empty husks.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.4)

23 “This divine māyā of Mine, made of the guṇas, is hard to overcome. But those who surrender to Me alone cross beyond this māyā.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 7.14)[9]

24 The jīva is Kṛṣṇa's eternal servant, but he has forgotten it. For that fault Māyā has bound him by the neck.[10]

25 If he then worships Kṛṣṇa and serves his guru, the net of Māyā falls away and he attains Kṛṣṇa's feet.

26 If the followers of the four *varṇas* and *āśramas* do not worship Kṛṣṇa, then even while performing their own duties they fall into the hell Raurava and sink there.[11]

27 "From the mouth, arms, thighs and feet of the Puruṣa the four *varṇas*, beginning with the brāhmaṇas, were born together with the *āśramas*, each distinct by its qualities." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.2)[12]

28 "Those among them who do not worship the Puruṣa, their own source and Lord, but disregard Him, fall from their position and sink into the depths." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.3)

29 The jñānī thinks, 'I have attained the state of liberation in this life (*jīvan-mukti*).' But in truth the intelligence does not become pure without devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

30 "O lotus-eyed Lord, others think themselves liberated, but their intelligence is impure, for they have no love for You. Though they rise with great hardship to the supreme position, they fall down from there, having neglected Your feet." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.2.32)[13]

31 Kṛṣṇa is like the sun, and Māyā is darkness. Where Kṛṣṇa is, Māyā has no power.[14]

32 "Māyā is ashamed to stand in the path of His sight; yet the foolish, bewildered by her, boast of 'I' and 'mine'." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.5.13)

33 If someone says even once, ‘Kṛṣṇa, I am Yours’, Kṛṣṇa carries him across, beyond the bondage of Māyā.[15]

34 “To one who surrenders to Me even once and prays, ‘I am Yours’, I always grant fearlessness. This is My vow.” (Rāmāyaṇa, Yuddha-kāṇḍa, 18.33)[16]

35 If one who desires liberation, worldly enjoyment or mystic perfections becomes truly intelligent, he then worships Kṛṣṇa with deep *bhakti-yoga*.

36 “Whether he is without desire, full of every desire, or desirous of liberation, a person of broad intelligence should worship the Supreme Person with intense *bhakti-yoga*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.3.10)

37 If one who has other desires worships Kṛṣṇa, Kṛṣṇa gives him His own feet even though he has not asked for them.

38 Kṛṣṇa says, ‘He worships Me, yet asks for sense pleasure. Giving up nectar, he asks for poison — he is a great fool.

39 But I am wise: why should I give sense objects to this fool? I will give him the nectar of My own feet and make him forget sense objects.’

40 “It is true that when men ask, the Lord grants what they ask for; but He does not give what would make them ask again. To those who worship Him, though they do not desire it, He Himself gives His own feet, tender as new shoots, which put an end to all other desires.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 5.19.26)[17]

41 One who worships Kṛṣṇa for the sake of some desire comes to taste Kṛṣṇa’s sweetness (*kṛṣṇa-rasa*). Then, giving up that desire, he longs to become His servant.

42 “Desiring a high position, I engaged in austerities, and I have attained You, who are hidden even from the gods and the greatest sages. I was searching for a piece of glass and found a divine jewel. O Master, my purpose is fulfilled; I ask for no boon.” (Hari-bhakti-sudhodaya, 7.28)

43 While wandering in worldly existence, someone by some good fortune is delivered, as a log carried by a river’s current comes to rest on the bank.

44 “But no — even I, lowly as I am, will surely see Acyuta. For even among those swept along by the river of time, someone at times reaches the shore.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.38.5)[18]

45 When by some good fortune someone’s worldly existence nears its end, he is delivered through the company of sādhus, and attraction (*rati*) for Kṛṣṇa awakens in him.

46 “O Acyuta, when a wandering soul’s worldly existence comes to its end, he meets the saints. And when he associates with the saints, attraction (*rati*) is born in him for You, the goal of the saints and the Lord of the high and the low.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.51.53)[19]

47 If Kṛṣṇa shows mercy to some fortunate soul, He Himself teaches him in the forms of the guru and the Indweller (*antaryāmī*).

48 “O Lord! Even if the wise lived as long as Brahmā and remembered with ever-growing joy all that You have done for them, they could not repay their debt to You. For, dispelling all that is inauspicious in embodied souls, You come to them from without as the ācārya and from within as the Supersoul, and reveal to them the way to Yourself.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.29.6)[20]

49 If, in the company of sādhus, faith in devotion to Kṛṣṇa arises, then prema, the fruit of bhakti, appears, and worldly existence comes to an end.

50 “For one who by good fortune has come to have faith in narrations about Me and the like, and who is neither disgusted with the world nor overly attached to it, *bhakti-yoga* grants perfection.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.20.8)[21]

51 Without the mercy of great souls no activity yields bhakti. Without it, worldly existence does not even come to an end, let alone devotion to Kṛṣṇa arise.

52 “O Rahūgaṇa, this is not attained by austerity, by worship, by renunciation or by household duties, nor by the Vedas, nor by worship of water, fire and the sun, without bathing in the dust of the feet of great souls.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 5.12.12)[22]

53 “So long as people do not accept a bath in the dust of the feet of the great, who own nothing (*niṣkiñcana*), their minds cannot touch the feet of Urukrama, whose purpose is to remove all *anarthas*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 7.5.32)[23]

54 ‘The company of sādhus, the company of sādhus!’ — so declare all the scriptures. Even a moment of *sādhu-saṅga* brings every perfection.

55 “We would not compare even heaven or liberation with a single moment in the company of those who are ever with the Lord — what then of the blessings mortals seek?” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.18.13)[24]

56 Addressing Arjuna, merciful Kṛṣṇa protected the whole world with this instruction:

57 “Hear again My supreme word, the most secret of all. You are very dear to Me, and therefore I shall tell you what is for your good.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 18.64)

58 “Fix your mind on Me, be My devotee, worship Me and bow down to Me. You will surely come to Me — truly I promise you this, for you are dear to Me.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 18.65)

59 His earlier commands concerned Vedic dharma, karma, yoga and jñāna. Having established all of these, He gave His final command, and it is the strongest.

60 If by the force of this command faith arises in the devotee, he gives up all other activities and worships Kṛṣṇa.

61 “One should go on performing one’s prescribed duties only so long as one has not grown weary of them, or so long as faith has not been born in hearing about Me and the like.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.20.9)[25]

62 The word *śraddhā* means trust: a very firm conviction that by rendering devotion to Kṛṣṇa one has fulfilled all one’s duties.[26]

63 “As by watering the root of a tree its trunk, branches and twigs are all nourished, and as by feeding the life-breath (*prāṇa*) all the senses are satisfied, so the worship of Acyuta is the worship of all.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 4.31.14)

64 A person who has faith is qualified for bhakti. According to his faith he is of the highest, the middle or the lowest level (*uttama*, *madhyama*, *kaniṣṭha*).

65 One who is expert in scripture and reasoning and whose faith is firm is an *uttama adhikārī*, of the highest qualification; he delivers the world.

66 One who does not firmly know the reasoning of scripture but has faith is a *madhyama adhikārī*, of the middle qualification; he is most fortunate.[27]

67 One whose faith is still tender is a *kaniṣṭha*, a beginner. Step by step he too will become a devotee of the highest level.

68 According to the degree of their *rati* and prema, devotees stand at different levels. The Eleventh Canto has described their characteristics.

69 "One who sees the Lord, the Soul of all, present in all beings, and sees all beings in the Lord, is the best of devotees (*bhāgavatottama*)." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.45)[28]

70 "One who shows love for the Lord, friendship for those who depend on Him, mercy to the ignorant and indifference to the hostile is a devotee of the middle level (*madhyama*)." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.46)

71 "One who with faith worships Hari only in the Deity, but does not honour His devotees or others, is known as a *prākṛta* devotee, one still on the worldly level." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.47)

72 All great qualities dwell in a Vaiṣṇava; all of Kṛṣṇa's qualities pass into His devotee.

73 "In one whose devotion to the Lord is free of desire all the gods dwell, and with them every virtue. But how can great qualities be found in one who is not devoted to Hari? Driven by his desires, his mind is forever running outward after what is passing." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 5.18.12)[29]

74 All these qualities are the marks of a Vaiṣṇava. They cannot all be told, so I shall only point to some of them.

75 A Vaiṣṇava is merciful, harms no one, is devoted to truth, equal to all, faultless, magnanimous, gentle, pure and without possessions (*akiñcana*);[30]

76 he is a benefactor of all, peaceful, with Kṛṣṇa as his only shelter, free from desire, free from worldly striving, steady, the conqueror of the six (*ṣaḍ-guṇa*);

77 he is moderate in eating, sober, giving honour to others while seeking none for himself, grave, compassionate, friendly, a poet, expert and sparing in speech.

78 "The sādhus are tolerant and compassionate, well-wishers of all embodied beings. They have no enemies and are peaceful; they follow the scriptures, and saintly conduct is their ornament." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.25.21)

79 "Service to the great is called the door to liberation, and the company of those attached to women the door to darkness. The great are those who are equal-minded, peaceful, free from anger, well-wishers of all and saintly." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 5.5.2)

80 The root from which devotion to Kṛṣṇa is born is *sādhu-saṅga*. And even when love for Kṛṣṇa is born, *sādhu-saṅga* remains its principal limb.

81 "O Acyuta, when a wandering soul's worldly existence comes to its end, he meets the saints. And when he associates with the saints, attraction (*rati*) is born in him for You, the goal of the saints and the Lord of the high and the low." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.51.53)[31]

82 "Therefore, O sinless ones, we ask you about the ultimate good. In this world even half a moment of association with saints is a treasure for humankind." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.30)

83 (Lord Kapila to His mother Devahūti:) "In the company of the saints there are talks revealing My power, delightful to the heart and to the ear. By relishing them one quickly comes to faith in Me, the path of liberation, and

after it to attraction (*rati*) and love (*prema-bhakti*).” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.25.25)[32]

84 To give up bad association — this is the conduct of a Vaiṣṇava. One who is attached to women is one kind of unholy person (*asādhu*); one who is not a devotee of Kṛṣṇa is the other.

85 “Truthfulness, purity, compassion, silence, intelligence, modesty, beauty, fame, forbearance, control of the mind and of the senses, and fortune — all go to ruin through the company of such people.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.31.33)

86 “One should never keep company with the restless and the foolish, with the unholy who have lost sight of the self, with those pitiable men who are pets for women to play with.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.31.34)

87 “From no other attachment does a man fall into such delusion and bondage as from the company of women and of those attached to women.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.31.35)

88 “Better to dwell in a cage amid blazing flames than to suffer the torment of living with people who have turned away from the thought of Kṛṣṇa.” (Kātyāyana-saṁhitā)

89 “Never even look upon people who are devoid of devotion to the Lord, whose piety is spent.” (Words of the Gosvāmipāda)[33]

90 Giving up all this, and the dharma of *varṇa* and *āśrama* as well, he becomes *akiñcana*, one who owns nothing, and takes shelter of Kṛṣṇa alone.[34]

91 “Give up all *dharmas* and take shelter of Me alone. I shall free you from all sins; do not grieve.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 18.66)[35]

92 Kṛṣṇa is affectionate to His devotees, grateful, all-capable and generous. No wise man would leave such a Kṛṣṇa to worship another.

93 "What wise man would approach any shelter but You? You love Your devotees, You are true to Your word, You are their friend and are grateful. To the friends who worship You, You give all they desire, and even Your own self — and You neither increase nor diminish." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.48.26)

94 When a wise person comes to know Kṛṣṇa's qualities, he gives up all else and worships Him. Of this Uddhava is the proof:

95 "Ah! Wishing to kill Him, the wicked Pūtanā made Him drink deadly poison from her breast — and still she attained the destination befitting His nurse. To whom else so merciful should we go for shelter?" (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.2.23)

96 The surrendered soul (*śaraṇāgata*) and the one who owns nothing (*akiñcana*) have the same characteristics; and within surrender there is also self-offering (*ātma-samarpaṇa*).

97 "Surrender (*śaraṇāgati*) is of six kinds: the resolve to accept what is favourable to devotion; the rejection of what is unfavourable; faith that He will protect; acceptance of Him as one's guardian; the offering of oneself; and humility." (Hari-bhakti-vilāsa, 11.417)[36]

98 "Saying with his words, 'I am Yours', knowing it so in his mind, and with his body taking shelter of the Lord's abode, the surrendered soul rejoices." (Hari-bhakti-vilāsa, 11.418)[37]

99 Taking shelter, he offers himself to Kṛṣṇa, and at that very moment Kṛṣṇa makes him like Himself.[38]

100 "When a mortal gives up all works and offers himself to Me, I wish to exalt him. Then he attains immortality and becomes fit to share with Me a nature like My own." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.29.34)

101 Now hear, Sanātana, the characteristics of *sādhana-bhakti*, devotion in practice, by which one obtains the great treasure of love for Kṛṣṇa.

102 "Devotion carried out by the senses, whose goal is *bhāva*, is called *sādhana-bhakti*. *Bhāva* is eternally perfect; to 'attain' it is to make it manifest in the heart." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.2.2)

103 Hearing and the other activities are its essential characteristic (*svarūpa-lakṣaṇa*). Its marginal characteristic (*taṭastha-lakṣaṇa*) is that the treasure of love arises from it.

104 Love for Kṛṣṇa is eternally perfect; it is never something produced by effort. Hearing and the other practices awaken it in the purified heart.[39]

105 This *sādhana-bhakti* is of two kinds: one is *vaidhī-bhakti*, devotion according to rules, and the other is *rāgānugā-bhakti*, devotion that follows spontaneous love.[40]

106 When one in whom *rāga*, spontaneous love, has not yet awakened worships at the bidding of the śāstra, the scriptures call this *vaidhī-bhakti*.

107 "Therefore, O descendant of Bharata, one who desires fearlessness must hear about, glorify and remember the Lord Hari, the Controller and the Soul of all." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.1.5)

108 "From the mouth, arms, thighs and feet of the Puruṣa the four *varṇas*, beginning with the brāhmaṇas, were born together with the *āśramas*, each distinct by its qualities." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.2)[41]

109 "Viṣṇu is always to be remembered and never to be forgotten. All injunctions and prohibitions are servants of these two rules alone." (Padmapurāṇa)

110 *Sādhana-bhakti*, with its many limbs, is very vast. In brief I shall tell you something of their essence.

111 Taking shelter at the feet of the guru; initiation (*dīkṣā*); serving the guru; learning true dharma and inquiring about it; following the path of the saints;

112 giving up one's own enjoyment for Kṛṣṇa's pleasure; living in a holy place of Kṛṣṇa; accepting only what is needed to maintain life; fasting on Ekādaśī;

113 honouring the *dhātrī* (*āmalakī*) and *aśvattha* trees, the cows, the brāhmaṇas and the Vaiṣṇavas; keeping far from offences in service, offences to the Holy Name and the like;

114 giving up the company of non-Vaiṣṇavas; not taking many disciples; not dabbling in many books, nor expounding them for the sake of argument;

115 remaining even-minded in loss and gain; not falling under the sway of grief and the like; not blaspheming other gods or other scriptures;

116 not listening to blasphemy of Viṣṇu or the Vaiṣṇavas, nor to worldly talk; not causing distress to any living being in mind or in speech;

117 hearing, glorifying, remembering, worshipping, offering prayers (*vandana*), attending on the Lord (*paricaryā*), servitude (*dāsya*), friendship (*sakhya*) and the offering of oneself (*ātma-nivedana*);

118 dancing and singing before the Deity; opening one's heart to Him (*vijñapti*); bowing down flat; rising to greet Him; following behind Him; going to holy places and temples;

119 circumambulation; reciting prayers; *japa*; saṅkīrtana; smelling the incense, garlands and fragrances offered to the Lord; honouring *mahāprasāda*;

120 seeing the *ārati*, the festivals and the Deity (*śrī-mūrti*); offering what is dear to oneself; meditation; serving *tadīya*, what is His own.[42]

121 *Tadīya*, "His own", means Tulasī, the Vaiṣṇavas, Mathurā and the *Bhāgavatam*. Service to these four is what Kṛṣṇa desires.

122 Making every endeavour for Kṛṣṇa's sake; looking to His mercy; celebrating His birthday and other festivals with the devotees;

123 surrendering to Him in every way; observing Kārttika and other vows — these are the sixty-four limbs (*aṅgas*) of devotion, and supreme is their greatness.

124 The company of saints; chanting the Holy Name; hearing the *Bhāgavatam*; living in Mathurā; serving the Deity with faith —

125 these five limbs are the best of all practices. Even slight contact with these five gives birth to love for Kṛṣṇa.[43]

126 "One should associate with a saint who shares one's aspiration, is affectionate and is superior to oneself, and one should relish the meaning of the *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* together with *rasikas*, those who know its taste." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, Pūrva-vibhāga, Sādhana-bhakti-laharī, 40)[44]

127 “With faith and with special love one should serve the feet of the Deity, chant the Holy Name in saṅkīrtana, and live in the beautiful region of Mathurā.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, Pūrva-vibhāga, Sādhana-bhakti-laharī, 41)[45]

128 “The power of these five limbs is wondrous and hard to grasp. Let alone faith in them: even the slightest connection with them gives birth to *bhāva* in those of good understanding, who are free from offence.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, Pūrva-vibhāga, Sādhana-bhakti-laharī, 87)[46]

129 Some practise one limb, some practise many; from steadiness (*niṣṭhā*) arise the waves of love.

130 Many devotees have attained perfection through a single limb; devotees such as Ambarīṣa practised many limbs.

131 “Parīkṣit attained perfection by hearing about Śrī Viṣṇu; Śukadeva, the son of Vyāsa, by glorifying Him; Prahlāda by remembering Him; Lakṣmī by serving His feet; Pṛthu by worship; Akrūra by offering prayers; Hanumān, lord of the monkeys, by servitude; Arjuna by friendship; and Bali by offering all he had and himself. All of them attained Kṛṣṇa in the highest way.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.2.265)[47]

132 “King Ambarīṣa engaged his mind on Kṛṣṇa’s lotus feet, his words in describing the qualities of the Lord of Vaikuṇṭha, his hands in cleaning Hari’s temple and similar service, and his ears in hearing the holy narrations of Acyuta.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 9.4.18)[48]

133 “He engaged his eyes in seeing Mukunda’s Deities and temples, his body in touching the bodies of the Lord’s servants, his sense of smell in the fragrance of the beautiful Tulasī at the Lord’s lotus feet, and his tongue in what had been offered to Him.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 9.4.19)

134 “He engaged his feet in walking to the Lord’s holy places, his head in bowing to the feet of Hṛṣīkeśa, and his desire in servitude, not in seeking enjoyment — so that there arose in him the attraction (*rati*) that takes shelter of the devotees of Uttamaśloka.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 9.4.20)[49]

135 One who gives up desires and worships Kṛṣṇa, honouring the command of scripture, is never in debt to the gods, the sages or the forefathers.

136 “O king, one who has given up his duties and with his whole being has gone for shelter to Mukunda, the giver of shelter, is no longer a servant or a debtor to the gods, the sages, other beings, his kinsmen, mankind or the forefathers.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.41)

137 One who gives up the dharma of rules and worships Kṛṣṇa’s feet never turns his mind to forbidden, sinful conduct.[50]

138 And if through ignorance he should fall into ‘sin’, Kṛṣṇa purifies him; He does not make him perform atonement.

139 “Should a dear devotee who worships the root of His feet, having given up every other feeling, somehow commit a sinful act, Hari, the Supreme Lord, seated in his heart, removes it all.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.42)

140 Knowledge (jñāna), renunciation (*vairāgya*) and the like are never limbs of devotion. Non-violence, restraint (*yama*), regulation (*niyama*) and the like follow along in the company of Kṛṣṇa’s devotees.[51]

141 “Therefore, for the yogī engaged in devotion to Me, whose mind is in Me, neither knowledge nor renunciation is, as a rule, the means to the highest good in this world.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.20.31)[52]

142 “O hunter, it is no wonder that you have non-violence and these other virtues: those who are engaged in devotion to Hari never cause pain to others.” (Skanda-purāṇa)

143 I have described to you the practice of *vaidhī-bhakti*. Now, Sanātana, hear the characteristics of *rāgānugā-bhakti*.

144 *Rāgātmikā-bhakti*, devotion whose very nature is *rāga*, is found preeminently in the people of Vraja. Devotion that follows it is called *rāgānugā*.[53]

145 “Natural, intense absorption in one’s beloved is *rāga*. Devotion filled with such *rāga* is here called *rāgātmikā*.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.2.272)[54]

146 Intense thirst for the beloved is the essential characteristic of *rāga*; absorption in the beloved is said to be its marginal characteristic.

147 Devotion full of *rāga* is named *rāgātmikā*. Hearing of it, some fortunate soul is filled with longing (*lobha*) for it.

148 Out of that longing he follows the mood of the people of Vraja. Such is the nature of *rāgānugā*: it does not wait upon the arguments of scripture.[55]

149 “Devotion that follows the *rāgātmikā* devotion shining, clearly manifest, in the people of Vraja is called *rāgānugā*.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.2.270)

150 “When one hears of the sweetness of their moods and the rest, and the intellect is drawn to it without waiting upon scripture or reasoning — that is the sign that longing has arisen.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.2.292)[56]

151 Its practice is of two kinds, external and internal. Externally, in the body of a practitioner (*sādhaka*), he hears and chants;[57]

152 and in his mind, contemplating his own perfected spiritual body (*siddha-deha*), he serves Kṛṣṇa in Vraja night and day.

153 "One who longs for the *bhāva* of the people of Vraja should serve, following them, both in the form of a *sādhaka* and in the perfected form." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.2.295)

154 Keeping close behind the dear one of Kṛṣṇa whom his heart has chosen, he serves without cease, his mind turned within.[58]

155 "Remembering Kṛṣṇa and that dearest devotee of His whom he has chosen as his own, and absorbed in narrations about them, he should always live in Vraja." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.2.294)

156 Servants, friends, parents and the others, and the beloveds: on the path of *rāga* each devotee is reckoned among them according to his own *bhāva*.[59]

157 (Lord Kapila to Devahūti:) "Those devoted to Me, for whom I am the beloved, the Self, son, friend, guru, well-wisher, deity and all they desire, are never lost in My abode of peace, and My weapon, time, does not devour them." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.25.38)[60]

158 "Again and again I bow to those in this world who always zealously meditate on Hari as their husband, son, well-wisher, brother, father or friend." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.2.308)[61]

159 In whoever practises *rāgānugā-bhakti* in this way, love (*prīti*) for Kṛṣṇa's feet arises.

160 When love is still a sprout, it has two names, *rati* and *bhāva*; by it Śrī Bhagavān Himself is won over.[62]

161 Thus I have described the *abhidheya*, the means by which one obtains loving service to Kṛṣṇa (*prema-sevā*).[63]

162 Now, Sanātana, I have told you of the *abhidheya*, *sādhana-bhakti*. I have told it in brief; it cannot be described in full."[64]

163 Whoever hears of *sādhana-bhakti*, the *abhidheya*, very soon obtains the treasure of love for Kṛṣṇa.

164 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. *Anubhāṣya*: *bhakti*, causeless service to Kṛṣṇa, was unknown even to the knowers of dharma in the Satya, Tretā and Dvāpara ages; Mahāprabhu proclaimed it to all in the age of Kali, the age of quarrel. ↩
2. The same verse as Ādi 10.2 (= Madhya 13.2); translation as there. ↩
3. The chapter continues the Lord's instruction to Sanātana (Madhya 20–21). Heading of the edition: "in all the Vedas and śāstras Kṛṣṇa alone is established as the *sambandha*". ↩
4. Heading of the edition: "words of a sage" (*muni-vākya*); the source of the verse is not named. ↩
5. *Anubhāṣya*: the potency and its possessor are non-different. "Potency" here must not be taken as *māyā-śakti*, which covers the nature of the jīva: the *svarūpa-śakti*, engaged only in the service of Kṛṣṇa Himself, abides inseparably with Him. ↩
6. Heading of the edition: in the countless Vaikuṇṭhas He sports in the forms of His own parts, the Viṣṇu forms, and in the universes in the forms of the jīvas. ↩
7. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: only by taking shelter of bhakti can karma and haṭha-yoga give the fruit of worldly enjoyment, and jñāna and rāja-yoga the fruits of

liberation and mystic perfection. ↩

8. *Anubhāṣya*: Śrī Nārada speaks thus to Vyāsadeva, who had found no satisfaction of heart, glorifying pure devotion to Hari, which is above all paths — karma, jñāna and the rest. ↩
9. The same verse as Madhya 20.121; translation as there. ↩
10. *Anubhāṣya*: māyā blinded the jīva who had forgotten that he is Kṛṣṇa's eternal servant, and put on his neck the chain of the three guṇas — the desire to enjoy. ↩
11. *Anubhāṣya*: though under worldly pride they may rise high, when their merit is spent they surely fall into the hell Raurava. ↩
12. Heading of the edition: *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam*, 11.5.2–3 (on verses 27–28). *Anubhāṣya*: the Puruṣa is the universal (*vairāja*) Brahmā; the sage Camasa answers King Nimi thus, describing the *daiva-varṇāśrama* favourable to bhakti and the fate of those who depart from it. ↩
13. *Anubhāṣya*: Brahmā and the gods pray thus to Bhagavān, who has appeared in the womb of Devakī; the "supreme position" (*paraṁ padam*), according to Śrīdhara Svāmī, is the place immediately next to *mokṣa*. ↩
14. Heading of the edition: where Kṛṣṇa is seen, māyā is not seen; where māyā is seen, Kṛṣṇa is not seen. ↩
15. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: not by habit, with the lips alone, but from the whole heart — with body, mind and words. ↩
16. Heading of the edition: the words of Śrī Rāmacandra in the *Rāmāyaṇa*, when Vibhīṣaṇa came to Him. ↩
17. Numbered as in the heading of the edition and the *Anubhāṣya* (5.19.26); in other editions — 5.19.27. ↩
18. *Anubhāṣya*: Akrūra reflects thus on the road to Gokula, where he is going to bring Rāma and Kṛṣṇa. ↩
19. *Anubhāṣya*: Mucukunda prays thus to Śrī Kṛṣṇa; the end of worldly existence (*bhavāpavarga*) comes by the Lord's mercy, when its time arrives. ↩
20. The same verse as Ādi 1.48; translation as there. ↩
21. *Anubhāṣya*: *nirviṇṇa* — one who holds to false (*phalgu*) renunciation; just such a person, full of faith, is qualified for bhakti-yoga. ↩
22. *Anubhāṣya*: the *avadhūta* Bharata instructs Rahūgaṇa, king of Sindhu and Sauvīra, thus; *ijyā* — Vedic rites, the worship of the gods; *nirvapaṇa* — sannyāsa; *gṛha* — the sacrifices of the householder. ↩
23. *Anubhāṣya*: Prahlāda answers Hiraṇyakaśipu, who asked where his Vaiṣṇava disposition came from. ↩

24. *Anubhāṣya*: the sages headed by Śaunaka glorify thus their association with Sūta, the *mahā-bhāgavata*. ↩
25. The same verse as Madhya 9.266; translation as there. ↩
26. *Anubhāṣya*: one who serves Kṛṣṇa need not discharge the duties of the worldly realm — the debts to the forefathers, to beings, to the gods and others; detachment, the best fruit of karma, accompanies the devotee of itself. ↩
27. The *Anubhāṣya* cites Śrī Rūpa: "One who is not so expert in the śāstras and the rest, but has faith, is of the middle level." ↩
28. The same verse as Madhya 8.274; translation as there. Heading of the edition: *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam*, 11.2.45–47 (on verses 69–71). ↩
29. The same verse as Ādi 8.58; translation as there. ↩
30. Heading of the edition: "the secondary (*taṭastha*) marks". *Anubhāṣya*: the essential (*svarūpa*) mark of a Vaiṣṇava is that Kṛṣṇa is his only shelter (*kṛṣṇaika-śaraṇa*, verse 76); all the rest are secondary. ↩
31. The same verse as 46; translation as there. ↩
32. The same verse as Ādi 1.60; translation as there. ↩
33. The edition's heading: "words of the Gosvāmipāda" (*gosvāmipādokti*). ↩
34. "All this" is the two kinds of bad association named in verse 84 (*Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*). *Anubhāṣya* (heading): this is the conduct of the *paramahaṁsa*, the Vaiṣṇava who has nothing of his own. ↩
35. The same verse as Madhya 8.63 and 9.265; translation as there. The verse number is not printed in the edition. ↩
36. The edition's heading: "words of the *Vaiṣṇava-tantra*"; the *Hari-bhakti-vilāsa* (11.417) quotes the verse from it. ↩
37. The edition's heading: *Hari-bhakti-vilāsa*, 11.418, quoting the *Vaiṣṇava-tantra*. ↩
38. *Anubhāṣya* (headings to 99–100): the Vaiṣṇava is non-different from Kṛṣṇa in nature — like Him, full of eternity, knowledge and bliss; this is not an identity of the jīva with God. ↩
39. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: it cannot be obtained by any *abhidheya* other than pure bhakti; prema itself is the *prayojana*, the supreme goal. The edition's heading: "attaining the pure *prayojana*". ↩
40. *Rāgānugā* means "following *rāga*": the spontaneous love is that of the eternal residents of Vraja (*rāgātmikā-bhakti*), and *rāgānugā* follows it (verses 147–150). ↩
41. The same verse as 27; translation as there. *Anubhāṣya* (heading): at the start of *vaidhī-bhakti*, before the stage of the *paramahaṁsa*, the *daiva-varṇāśrama-dharma* is followed; here is its origin. ↩

42. *Tadīya*, “what is His own”: by verse 121, Tulasī, the Vaiṣṇavas, Mathurā and the *Bhāgavatam*. ↩
43. The condition is freedom from offence (verse 128). ↩
44. Reference by the edition’s heading (in another numbering, 1.2.91). *Anubhāṣya*: *rasikas* are those versed in service to Kṛṣṇa; the meaning of the *Bhāgavatam* is not to be relished with a grammarian who has abandoned bhakti, a mere scholar of words, one attached to women, a Māyāvādī, an offender to the Name, one who makes a living from the *Bhāgavatam*, or a worldly man. ↩
45. Reference by the edition’s heading (in another numbering, 1.2.90). *Anubhāṣya*: living in Śrī Māyāpura and the other abodes of Śrī Gaura’s pastimes, in Śrī Kṣetra and in Vraja-maṇḍala is not different from living in Mathurā. ↩
46. Reference by the edition’s heading (in another numbering, 1.2.238). ↩
47. The edition’s heading: “a verse cited in the *Padyāvalī* and in the *Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu* (Pūrva-vibhāga, Sādhana-bhakti-laharī)”. The verse number is not printed in the edition. ↩
48. The edition’s heading: *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam*, 9.4.18–20 (on verses 132–134). ↩
49. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: a *rati* whose shelter is the devotees of Kṛṣṇa; *Anubhāṣya*: “following the servants of Hari”. ↩
50. *Anubhāṣya* (heading): a Vaiṣṇava is never a sinner, and a sinner is never a Vaiṣṇava. ↩
51. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* (on 141): at first they may be of slight help to bhakti, but they are not counted among its limbs. The edition’s heading: jñāna and *vairāgya* are only two sons who follow bhakti. ↩
52. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: bhakti is independent; jñāna, *vairāgya* and yoga may at first be of slight help to it, but they are not counted among its limbs. The verse number is not printed in the edition. ↩
53. *Mukhyā*, “principal”: such bhakti exists nowhere else (*Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*); the path of the practitioner is *rāgānugā*, following the people of Vraja. ↩
54. Reference as in the edition’s heading (Sādhana-bhakti-laharī, 272). ↩
55. That is, his longing was not awakened by scriptural argument, and he does not accept arguments raised against his awakened taste (see verse 150). This is not a disregard of scripture: according to the *Anubhāṣya*, devotees in whom taste has truly awakened (*jāta-ruci*) are deeply versed in the reasoning of scripture, while the *prākṛta-sahajiyās*, who imagine themselves *rāgānugās* and abandon the books of devotion and the path of Śrī Rūpa, have no such taste. ↩
56. This is how longing (*lobha*) is born, not a rejection of scripture (see the note to verse 148). *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: on hearing of the sweetness of the moods

of the people of Vraja, the intellect rests on this longing — and it is this that gives the right to *rāgānugā-bhakti*. ↩

57. *Anubhāṣya* (heading): thus, in two ways — in the body of a *sādhaka* and in the *siddha-deha* — *rāgānugā-bhakti* is practised by one who is free from *anarthas*. ↩
58. The *rāgānugā* devotee serves by following a resident of Vraja (*ānugatya*), not by imitating him; *Anubhāṣya* (heading): following the guru at every moment. ↩
59. *Anubhāṣya* (heading): the *rāgānugā* devotee serves Kṛṣṇa in four rasas; *śānta-rasa* has no place here. ↩
60. *Anubhāṣya*: *śānta-rūpe* — in Me, or in the eternal abode of Vaikuṇṭha; *na naṅkṣyanti* — they never become impersonal, bereft of enjoyment. ↩
61. The verse number is not printed in the edition. ↩
62. *Anubhāṣya* (heading): this is *bhāva-bhakti*, or *rati* — love for Kṛṣṇa not yet fully developed, which draws Kṛṣṇa. ↩
63. *Anubhāṣya* (heading): until *bhāva*, or *rati*, awakens, the *abhidheya* is *sādhana*; from it the *prayojana* is obtained. ↩
64. The second line is the same as in Madhya 9.358. Here ends Mahāprabhu's speech begun in verse 3. ↩